

Chapter 2

Crusaders and conspirators

Terrorists, defenders of the people, have the right to ignore the public conscience, which always denies the defence of the people.

G. Tarnovski, *Terrorism and Routine*, 1880

The good terrorist

At some stage in thinking about terrorism, we encounter the enigmatic figure of the ‘good terrorist’—the ironic title of Doris Lessing’s 1984 novel dissecting the life of one of the *groupuscules* which infested Europe in the 1970s and 1980s (to whom we will return in [Chapter 4](#)). Good terrorists are those whose actions are justified by the oppressiveness of the system they oppose. A certain admiration, however reluctant, marks even conservative accounts of the modern pioneers of terrorism, the 19th-century Russian populists: a recognition that unlike terrorists of the right, they ‘genuinely believed in a free and nonviolent society’. This was the key to their conviction, which can be plausibly attributed to nearly all terrorists, that any change would be for the better.

Today’s terrorists are rarely seen in this light. Like many of the most durable prejudices, the stereotype of the terrorist as a psychopathic monster has survived a lot of academic efforts to modify it. Most academic studies point to the view that terrorists are generally remarkable for their sheer ordinariness. The qualities popularly supposed to be needed to carry out terrorist acts—at best a lack of pity, at worst a malign will to evil—are either not needed, or if needed are regrettably

common. There have been arguments that a significant number of terrorists experienced difficult childhoods—like Lessing’s Alice—but these cannot (yet, at least) be systematized. Most of the considerable energy devoted to writing about ‘the terrorist personality’ has so far been wasted.

So who becomes a terrorist? The answer is likely to be that it depends on the circumstances. Terrorist organizations differ markedly in how they recruit their members. Some (particularly the revolutionary kind) will indeed require fanatics, ideologues, dreamers; others (notably the nationalist kind) may be so embedded in their communities that enlistment resembles a rite of passage. For Geula Cohen, the Lehi (in which she became a leading recruiter) was a band of poets:

The soldier was weighed down by his weapons ... he could never catch up with the poet who took to the air, sustained in his flight by visions of higher worlds. Eventually, of course, the soldier would reach the point where the poet last stood, and he would hear echoes of the poet’s song. From these echoes he would spark a conflagration.

Terrorists are most likely to be young—probably in their 20s—and quite likely to be educated. The perfect deed of the good terrorist is assassination. Classical tyrannicide was admired if it removed an oppressor instantly and precisely. In complex modern states the assassin might pick a symbolic or a functional target—the monarch or his chief of police, say. The Russian revolutionary organization *Narodnaya Volya* (People’s Will) struck at both, most famously Tsar Alexander II; and so launched a fashion that seemed, in the last couple of decades of the 19th century, to threaten (in bourgeois eyes) the whole civilized world. The readiness of these assassins to risk their own lives—in many cases a certainty of capture and execution—compelled a mixture of fascination, admiration, and horror. (As, a century later, has the emergence of ‘suicide bombers’.) While it is useful to be reminded that terrorism is adopted because ‘it works’, this is not the whole story. ‘A terrorist’, as Italian researchers have suggested,

does not simply weigh risks against the likelihood of success, as is normally the case, but adds into the equation the abstract value of the cause for which he or she is fighting. This is the reason why traditional notions of deterrence are ineffective against such a subject.

The first attempt to establish an international convention against terrorism,

following the assassination of King Alexander of Yugoslavia in 1934, was beset by the sort of problems evident in one British official's view of its object: 'to discountenance the use for political purposes of methods which all civilized opinion must condemn'. But who were to be the judges (and executioners) of civilization? The belief that there was some moral criterion against which 'terrorist' methods could be identified proved illusory. As the same official also noted,

If all states were at all times decently governed, presumably anyone who attempted by force to overthrow an existing government should be a *hostis humani generis*; but when the government is itself a terrorist government, I think a person who endeavours to overthrow it by the only means available is not necessarily to be so regarded.

Freedom fighters?

That one man's terrorist is another woman's freedom fighter—or one woman's terrorism is another man's heroism—is surely a commonplace of our times. A truism. But is it true? Can it help us to understand the nature of terrorism? Many writers on terrorism dismiss it, but we can usefully look at the reasons why such relativism has been so noticeable, and at ways of testing whether terrorism can really be a strategy of liberation.

The truism has a historical foundation. Terrorism as a distinctive political concept got its name (and much of its unattractive reputation) from the actions of the holders of state power, perhaps the first modern regime—the French Convention of Year II of the French Revolution (1793–4). Since then, governments have been on any quantitative measure the most prolific users of terroristic violence (see [Chapter 3](#)). Yet there is no hint of this in the dominant official discourse, whether of national or of international law. In that discourse, terrorism is used by extremists—rebels—against the established order—the state.

It has never been too hard to detect the hypocrisy or double standards in operation here, not just for anarchists with their insistence that the violence of their protests was puny in comparison with the 'violence inherent in the system'. As the 20th century wore on, onlookers could hardly fail to notice that states threatened by far less radical movements routinely branded their resistance

methods as terrorism, and dismissed their perpetrators from the realm of politics as moral outlaws. Sometimes, though, states did come to political terms with these ‘thugs’ and ‘murderers’ who allegedly owed their power to violent intimidation of the law-abiding majority. A leading example of such outlaws brought in from the cold was Michael Collins of the IRA in 1921; but plenty more have followed.

Some observers have moved quickly from noting the hypocrisy of the state’s use of the terrorist label to insisting on the equal—or greater—culpability of the state in the use of terrorist violence. Radical critics like Noam Chomsky and Richard Falk have projected a symmetrical image of reckless violence committed by rebels and governments alike. But it was not necessary to go this far to conclude that the promiscuous use of the terrorist label had by the 1970s robbed it of any precision or analytical value. It was simple enough too for ‘terrorists’ to hurl the label back at their accusers; thus the Jewish ‘underground’ denounced ‘the British terror’ and pronounced the British administration, army, and police in Palestine to be ‘terrorist organizations’; in 2002, the al-Aqsa brigades declared themselves ‘honoured’ to be labelled a terrorist organization by the world’s greatest terrorist, the US government. The ‘terrorism-heroism’ truism may have represented not just a suspicion that facts were being misrepresented, but also an acceptance that the reality was too complex to fit these rigid categories.

Freedom fighters need some way of overthrowing tyranny, oppression, or imperialism. Is terrorism a viable means of doing this? Modern terrorism really took off with a technological revolution that seemed to make almost anything possible—the invention of dynamite. This high explosive seemed to offer the prospect of reversing the crushing historic imbalance of power between oppressors and oppressed. Anarchists led the way in testing its efficacy. In 1886, for instance, the throwing of a bomb at police during an anarchist-led workers’ demonstration in Chicago—killing a policeman and triggering a riot in which several other people were killed—created a huge sensation. The public impact of the event was tremendous. But what did it portend? Nobody admitted—much less claimed—responsibility. Still, when the anarchist activist Albert Parsons was arraigned for conspiracy to murder, he denied involvement but stoutly maintained in court that dynamite ‘made all men equal and therefore free’. This was a heady message. Frank Harris used a hypothesis about the Haymarket explosion as the basis for his remarkable novel *The Bomb*, which presented a notably heroic and charismatic bomb-maker, Louis Lingg, as its key character.

Significantly, Harris played up the concentrated destructive power of the new explosives to have Lingg make bombs small enough to hide in his mouth.

So far, though, the faith placed in the destructive power that technology has placed in the hands of small groups, or even individuals, has been disappointed. Maybe the quantum leap possible in the future, with weapons of mass destruction (WMD), will change this. We shall return to this issue later. But up to now, neither bombs nor any other technological miracles have made men free. Although the 20th century produced plenty of successful ‘wars of national liberation’, often with a significant terrorist dimension, none succeeded by terrorism alone. And the most striking failures have been those of the purest adherents to terrorist methods—the urban guerrillas of the 1970s and 1980s, the German Red Army, the Italian BR, and so on—the result of whose campaigns has typically been not the overthrow of states but the intensification of state and public security measures, a general degradation in the quality of freedom.

Can terrorism liberate? Or might the process of terror have ‘corrupting consequences that reverberate for decades’? Certainly the apocalyptic dreams which have animated many terrorist groups have never materialized. In this sense, those, like the distinguished historian Walter Laqueur, who argue that terrorism has always failed are right. Shock and horror have their limits. As in war, perhaps, the experience of violent conflict can shift social tolerances. Shock wears off, or at least some effects of shock are modulated; the initial idea that such a situation is intolerable and that something must break (a very pervasive initial reaction in stable, orderly societies) is replaced by a realization that it won’t necessarily do so. Ordinary people probably wake up to this long before the terrorists. In Britain during the 1970s, there was a striking instance of this with the half-accepted, half-repudiated—but wholly unprecedented in public rhetoric—notion of an ‘acceptable level’ of IRA violence.

This was probably not meant to signal a let-up in the state’s jealous monopoly of violence so much as to argue the impossibility of dealing with terrorists. If we ask how political violence is ‘normally’ resolved in liberal-democratic polities, it is by the standard mix of controlled repression and limited concession. Terrorists, however, are mostly unamenable to limited concessions: it is by setting absolute, non-negotiable demands, as much as by using violence, that they opt out of the political process. Until they and the state can speak at least a few halting phrases in the same political language, the only response will be

containment and coexistence rather than interaction. If terrorism cannot be eliminated, it must perforce at some level be tolerated—and it can be.

So is there a difference between terrorists and freedom fighters? On the historical record, those who have adopted a purely terrorist strategy have not been successful liberators. Conversely, the liberators—Collins included—were not pure or absolute terrorists. The crucial distinctions between terrorism and war point to the limited efficacy of terrorism in pursuit of radical objectives. Its corrosive and possibly corrupting effect on social bonds could in any case modify the operation of freedom itself. While we should still pay attention to Frantz Fanon's assertion of the liberating value of violence for the oppressed —'it frees the native from his inferiority complex, his despair and his inaction: it makes him fearless and restores his self-respect'—the problem is that terrorist violence does not fulfil Fanon's democratic promise—'liberation has been the business of each and all'. ([Box 2](#).) At the bottom line, its achievements have been negative: as Régis Debray lamented of those emblematic 'good terrorists' of the 1970s, the Tupamaros (see [Chapter 5](#)), they became 'the gravediggers of liberal Uruguay'.

Box 2

The terrorist is noble, terrible, irresistibly fascinating, for he combines in himself the two sublimities of human grandeur: the martyr and the hero. From the day he swears in the depths of his heart to free the people and the country, he knows he is consecrated to death. He goes forth to meet it fearlessly, and can die without flinching, not like a Christian of old, but like a warrior accustomed to look death in the face.

Proud as Satan rebelling against God, he opposed his own will to that of the man who alone, amid a nation of slaves, claimed the right of having a will ... The terrorist is immortal. His limbs may fail him, but, as if by magic, they regain their vigour, and he stands erect, ready for battle after battle until he has laid low his enemy and liberated the country. And already he sees that enemy falter, become confused, cling desperately to the wildest means, which can only hasten his end.

Sergei Stepniak-Kravchinski, *Underground Russia* (1883)

International terrorism

In the 1980s, a new spectre arose to haunt the Western world: ‘international terrorism’. It was heralded in the bizarre career of ‘Carlos’, a terrorist odd-job man who was turned by enterprising and imaginative journalists in the mid-1970s into a global phenomenon. It was given shape above all by one book, Claire Sterling’s *The Terror Network*, published in 1981, which traced a vast, unified global organization not only inspired but directly controlled by the USSR. This awe-inspiring perception chimed with the political rhetoric of the Thatcher–Reagan period: the struggle against the ‘evil empire’. In 1981, the US Secretary of State, Alexander Haig, accused the Soviet Union of ‘training, funding, and equipping international terrorists’. Though he stopped short of the full Sterling measure, the concept of international terrorism was firmly established. Despite its obvious improbabilities, not to say absurdities, the terror network idea was subjected to surprisingly little criticism until the end of the Cold War eviscerated it.

Sterling achieved her effects by none-too-subtle sleight of hand—by omitting to define terrorism, she was able to incorporate a wide range of groups and incidents in her canvas. Following practice established by the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) (which did at least have a clear definition of international terrorist events), she inflated her statistics by counting all acts, of any kind, of any group labelled as terrorist. Her standard of proof was undemanding. Most seriously, perhaps, she glossed over the historical and political context of terrorist groups, and the often sharp doctrinal differences between them. For her, the inherent fairness of Western societies meant that the only possible explanation for terrorist action was outside interference: there could be no real domestic terrorists.

Of course, it was undeniable that terrorism took on a distinctly international cast in the 1970s. The establishment of airliner hijacking as the most newsworthy terrorist action automatically internationalized the issue (see [Figure 4](#)), and its pioneers, the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), were an international organization by default, since they were exiled from the land they claimed: as the US State Department still puts it, ‘Palestinians are considered stateless

people'. And they did indeed train in the Soviet Union, which did indeed, via its satellite states, supply them with equipment. Perhaps the most dangerous terrorist weapon of this time was Semtex ('magic marble'), a powerful 'plastic' explosive, invented by Stanislav Brebera in the Czech town of Semtin in 1966. Easy to cut and mould, usable in a wide range of conditions, undetectable by sniffer dogs, and available in a choice of colours, Semtex was (almost literally) a gift to terrorists. What dynamite had been to the late 19th century, Semtex was to the late 20th (only, unlike Alfred Nobel, its inventor did not make a fortune from it). During the 1970s, some 690 tonnes of Semtex were exported from Czechoslovakia to Libya alone, enough to make over a million bombs of the strength used to destroy Pan Am 103 over Lockerbie in 1988; enough, as President Havel ruefully admitted later, 'to support terrorism throughout the world for 150 years'. From Libya, then regarded as the USSR's key Third-World surrogate, it was certainly distributed to many terrorist groups, including the Basque separatist group Euskadi ta Askatasuna (ETA; Land and Freedom) and the Irish Republican Party (IRA). Such aid was a tremendous help to these organizations, but there is no evidence that it was decisive in keeping them active, much less in creating them.



4. The emblematic drama of 'international' terrorism in the 1970s: a BOAC VC10, one of three airliners hijacked by the Popular Front for the

Liberation of Palestine (PFLP) in September 1970, and destroyed on a Jordanian airfield.

Some terrorist organizations were distinctly international in outlook, but so, of course, had been their predecessors a century earlier. The assassination of President Sadi Carnot of France by an Italian anarchist in 1894, for instance, was in a sense paralleled by the actions of the German Rote Armee Fraktion (RAF) and Bewegung zwei Juni (B2J) in the 1970s—aimed at international capitalism and US imperialism (see [Chapter 4](#)). Such incidents as the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand by a Serb at Sarajevo in 1914, or of King Alexander in Marseilles in 1934, were likewise international, certainly in the legal sense of acts ‘which disrupt international relations, and which the international community considers contrary to desirable norms of behaviour’. But in these cases, the description ‘international’ hardly describes the character of the groups involved, which were intensely nationalist.

There is a distinction between calculatedly ‘international’ actions and actions that happen incidentally to cross national boundaries. For the latter events—much the most common—many writers have used the term ‘transnational’. But even though there is now a considerable literature on this topic, more often than not there is a lot of slippage between these key terms, and others such as ‘global’, which suggests that most writers still conflate them into a single phenomenon. The most careful systematic studies of this issue have stressed the difficulty of anything more than episodic cooperation between disparate terrorist groups; one has concluded emphatically that ‘No “terrorist international” exists’.

A similar miasma of imprecision hangs about the associated term ‘state-sponsored terrorism’, much beloved of the US State Department and conservative analysts. The heyday of this menace was the 1980s, when, according to one expert,

communist states, especially the Soviet Union and their surrogates, as well as a number of other militant totalitarian regimes like Iran, Libya and Syria, are actively exporting terrorists and terror techniques into other countries ... their activity is a manifestation of transnational state-sponsored terrorism. They indoctrinate, fund, train, arm sub-state groups of diverse national origins to act as their tools, using psychological warfare and propaganda to create severe psycho-social or political conflict in contemporary life.

One would need to ask how such opportunist action could produce such dire effects, and more level-headed writers have indeed suggested that a stress on the role of state sponsorship can be seriously misleading. The full-blown state sponsorship syndrome has been likened to the discredited theories put forward by the French army during the Algerian war, portraying the Arab struggle as externally manipulated and denying the authenticity of indigenous nationalist motivation. US insistence on the central role of state sponsorship survived such cautionary advice, however; and several of the old 'rogue states' were re-identified by George W. Bush as part of an 'axis of evil'.

Superterror, cyberterror?

Can things get any worse? We need to assess the possibility of terrorists acquiring and using WMD—chemical, biological, and nuclear weapons. Although they did not involve such weapons, the unprecedented scale of the 9/11 attacks seemed to bring this exponential expansion of destruction a big step closer. The alarm had been raised some time earlier: in 1998 the US Secretary of Defense declared that 'the question is no longer if this will happen, but when'. In 1997, the National Defense Panel had urged that the US army should refocus its attention on coping with major domestic emergencies, using the Army Reserve and National Guard to train local authorities in chemical and biological weapon contamination and detection; to assist in casualty treatment, evacuation, and quarantining; and in the restoration of infrastructure and public services after a disaster. President Clinton's 1999 budget assigned hundreds of millions of dollars to such response programmes as constructing decontamination units, stockpiling vaccines and antibiotics, improving detection methods for chemical and biological agents, and special-forces training. As one commentator pointed out, 'the bill for these preparations could add up to tens of billions of dollars in the coming decades'.

In technological terms, the risks are undeniably increasing. The proliferation of nuclear weapons in the latter part of the 20th century began to dilute the monopoly of the superpowers. The collapse of the Soviet Union raised some worrying questions about the security of weapons and materials (especially the reported disappearance of a number of the KGB's (Komitet Gosudarstvennoy Bezopasnosti) special suitcase-sized bombs; though this may turn out to be due to poor accounting rather than theft or sale). And even if the security of military weapons could be guaranteed, it is not just weapons but knowledge that has

proliferated. Fissile materials are harder to restrict. It seems likely that really determined terrorist groups could get hold of weapons-grade plutonium (Pu-239), though enriched uranium-235 (HEU) would be harder to obtain, and it is the latter that might more easily be detonated. The formidable problems of weapon-building, and indeed of delivery (which may defeat the capacity of most terrorist groups), may be partly circumvented by making so-called 'dirty bombs', designed to maximize contamination rather than explosive power. Deadly chemical and biological agents are also becoming easier to acquire. Once again, half the difficulty of using such weapons lies in delivering them, but it would be hard to argue that these difficulties can never be overcome—whether by skill or by sheer luck. So the technical possibility of 'superterrorism' by WMD must be faced.

The question that needs to be raised, however, is one of psychology as well as technology: are terrorists really eager to use such weapons? And does this prospect, as a US judge declared as far back as 1981, entail 'a clear and present danger to the very existence of civilization itself'? Or is this another example of what critics see as deliberate drumming-up of public support for an aggressive foreign policy? There are certainly grounds for caution. A sceptical assessment of the threat suggested three major reasons why it might be exaggerated: sloppy thinking, vested interests, and morbid fascination. The 'prophets of doom' pile all forms of terrorism into a single global menace, making it seem far bigger and more coherent than it is. (As with the habitual characterization of any individual who plans more than one attack as a 'terrorist mastermind'.) The real issue is not one of capability but of motivation: what political group could possibly benefit from using WMD? 'Only a rare, extremist mindset completely devoid of political and moral considerations will consider launching such an attack.' Of course, many people, including powerful interests like defence contractors—such as Dycor, manufacturers of contaminant monitoring systems—and indeed the burgeoning official counterterrorist establishment are quite ready to suggest that many if not most terrorists fit this bill. Thirty years of study has, however, made clear that terrorism usually involves predictable rather than wild behaviour, and the majority of terrorist organizations can in principle be identified by fairly low-level intelligence systems.

Alarmism seems to be a natural by-product of media coverage of terrorism, and for the mass media superterrorism is an irresistible topic. 'People love to be horrified.' But this banal fact does not tell us very much about whether the thrill

of fear has any rational basis. Nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons have a special capacity to get under people's skins: a visceral dread of poisons may be the reason why these weapons, unlike high explosives, have been categorized as morally unacceptable. If we make an inventory of the expanding range of technologies open to extremist organizations, there is plainly a wide scope for exploiting these potent phobias. And even if we may expect that most terrorists will continue to avoid such weapons for a mixture of moral and pragmatic reasons, there are several reasons why some terrorists might not. Religious extremists could find exemplars in the behaviour of gods like Jehovah, who visited his enemies with massive destruction; or holy men like Phineas (the core myth for some of the white supremacist groups known as Christian Patriots), who 'purified' the community by murdering the chief of his tribe. Millenarianism likewise may lead to demonstrative rather than instrumental violence. (Quite a lot of counterterrorist energy was expended on studying such groups in the last years of the 20th century, though the feared spate of activity in 'Y2K' (year 2000) never materialized.) In the secular sphere, emulation of Hitler might well validate the use of mass destruction by neo-Nazi groups.

One of the pioneers of the modern study of terrorism, Walter Laqueur, recently offered an even wider phalanx of potential users of WMD. A quarter-century on from his first work on the subject, which was notable for its sceptical, anti-alarmist tone, Laqueur was distinctly more pessimistic about the dangers posed by terrorism—or perhaps not 'traditional' terrorism so much as its postmodern half-sibling, the use of mass-destruction methods by individuals or small groups without any recognizable political agenda. WMD have undeniably transformed their power; the half-mad 'professor' of Joseph Conrad's *Secret Agent* and his real-life successor the 'Unabomber' may now no longer be marginal figures. But the sheer quirkiness, if not outright nihilism, of such 'terrorists' seems to undermine the possibility of any coherent response.

There is ongoing speculation, too, about the threat of so-called 'cyberterror' (as distinct from the use of the Internet to plan terrorist operations). Many cyber attacks have already occurred, some on a large scale, but so far they have been mounted by state agencies, criminals, or lone hackers—'hacktivists'—claiming to act in the public interest. Terrorist groups could certainly use such attacks, although it is doubtful whether they would fit a terrorist strategy—however well they may work for criminal extortion. While those that have happened so far have caused some economic damage and created some insecurity, they have not

involved violence or the threat of it, and these have so far been central to the understanding of terrorism. The kind of damage to state security threatened by cyber warfare would seem more relevant to a traditional inter-state power contest than to terrorists. Here we may be pushing the bounds of a usable concept of terrorism.

So even if we suspect that judges or politicians who proclaim ‘a clear and present danger to civilization’ are distorting the traditional safeguards against the abuse of executive power, it is not at all simple to assess what kinds of financial and social costs should reasonably be paid to provide some sense of security. The financial costs have certainly become staggering, not just through the visible budgets of post-9/11 organizations like the US Department of Homeland Security—whose budget runs at over \$40 billion—but also the incalculable economic costs of air-travel security. But social costs could be higher still. Six months after the 9/11 attacks, the American jurist Ronald Dworkin warned that the biggest damage resulting from the counterterrorist reaction had been to the long-cherished American legal defences of individual freedom. Though nobody would dare to suggest publicly that such damage was greater than the mass killing in the Twin Towers, it may have a more pernicious long-term effect on the quality of our life.